

The apostles

Not only did the apostles themselves declare the New Testament writings to be Scripture, which would elicit reverence and care in their treatment, they expressly warned the believers to be on their guard against false teachers. Consider Acts 20:28-31. “So take heed to yourselves and to all the flock, in which the Holy Spirit has placed you as overseers, to shepherd the congregation of the Lord and God¹ which He purchased with His own blood. Because I know this, that after my departure savage wolves will come in among you, not sparing the flock. Yes, men will rise up from among you yourselves, speaking distorted things, to draw away the disciples after them. Therefore be alert.” Could Paul be any clearer?

Now consider Galatians 1:6-9. “I am sadly surprised that you are turning away so quickly from the one who called you by the grace of Christ, to a different gospel—it is not a mere variation, but certain people are unsettling you and wanting to distort the Gospel of the Christ. Now even if we, or an angel out of heaven, should preach any other gospel to you than what we have preached to you, let him be accursed! As we have just said, I here emphatically repeat: If anyone preaches any other gospel to you than what you have received, let him be accursed!!”² Could Paul be any more emphatic? Note that Paul is claiming to be competent to define the only true Gospel of Christ, and he could only do so genuinely by divine inspiration.

Now consider 2 Peter 2:1-2. “However, there were also false prophets among the people, just as, indeed, there will be false teachers among you, who will introduce destructive heresies, even denying the Owner who bought them (bringing on themselves swift destruction). And many will follow their licentious ways, because of which the way of the Truth will be defamed.” Peter warned the believers to be on their guard against false teachers.

And then there is 2 John 7 and 9-11. “Now many deceivers have come into the world,³ who do not acknowledge Jesus Christ as coming in

¹ The sheep belong to the Lord, not to the elders. Some 7% of the Greek manuscripts omit ‘the Lord and’, as in most versions. “The Lord and God” refers to Jesus.

² ‘Other gospels’ would seem to be in plentiful supply; those who promote them are under a curse.

³ Some 82% of the Greek manuscripts have “come into” rather than ‘go out into’ (as in most versions). The 18% presumably have the deceivers going out from the church into the world, but that is not John’s point. The deceivers have been introduced into the world by Satan, the original and boss deceiver.